Lead Vendor Comparison Scorecard

A Systematic Framework for Evaluating and Choosing the Right Aged Lead Provider

From HowToWorkLeads.com — The Aged Lead Playbook

Why You Need a Scorecard

Not all lead vendors are created equal. The difference between a good vendor and a bad one isn't just the quality of the data — it's whether the leads fit your business model, your budget, and your capacity to work them. This scorecard gives you a structured way to evaluate vendors side by side, so you make decisions based on evidence instead of sales pitches.

Use this scorecard to:

- Compare 2-4 vendors before committing to a bulk purchase
- Re-evaluate your current vendor against alternatives quarterly
- Have an objective conversation with your team about lead sourcing
- Identify which factors matter most for your specific business

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The 10 Evaluation Categories

Each category is scored on a 1-5 scale. Below, you'll find what each score means and what to look for.

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1. Data Quality (Weight: High)

How accurate and complete is the lead data?

Score	Meaning

1	Frequent wrong numbers, fake names, incomplete records (>30% bad data)
2	Noticeable data issues — wrong numbers and missing fields in 15-30% of records
3	Acceptable — 10-15% of records have issues, most are workable
4	Good quality — under 10% bad data, names and numbers are mostly accurate
5	Excellent — verified data, consistently under 5% bad records, phone + email both valid

What to check:

- Request a sample batch (25-50 leads) before buying in volume
- Call 20 leads from the sample — track wrong numbers, disconnected lines, wrong person
- Check if email addresses bounce when you send your first campaign
- Look for complete records: first name, last name, phone, email, state, inquiry type

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2. Lead Freshness (Weight: High)

How old are the leads, and is the age accurately represented?

Score	Meaning
1	Leads are significantly older than advertised, or age is not disclosed
2	Age ranges are vague ("30-180 days"), some leads are clearly recycled multiple times
3	Age is disclosed and generally accurate, but ranges are broad
4	Specific age tiers available (30-60, 60-90, 90-120), mostly accurate
5	Exact date of inquiry provided on each lead, verified and transparent

What to check:

- Ask: "What is the exact date the lead was generated?"
- Ask: "How many times has this lead been sold?"
- Test: Call a batch and ask prospects when they originally inquired — does it match?
- Fresher aged leads (30-60 days) should cost more than older leads (90-180 days)

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3. Return Policy (Weight: High)

What happens when you get bad data?

Score	Meaning
1	No returns, no refunds, no credits — all sales final
2	Credits only for obviously fake/disconnected numbers, slow process, limits apply
3	Reasonable return policy for bad data (wrong numbers, disconnects), 48-72 hour window
4	Strong return policy — credits for bad data within 5-7 days, easy submission process
5	Best-in-class — credits or replacements for any bad data, simple online portal, fast turnaround

What to check:

- Read the return policy before you buy — in writing, not just verbal
- Ask: "What qualifies for a return?" (disconnected? wrong person? DNC?)
- Ask: "How do I submit a return request, and how long does it take?"
- Red flag: Any vendor who refuses to put their return policy in writing

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4. Pricing Transparency (Weight: Medium)

Is pricing clear, fair, and consistent?

Score	Meaning
1	Pricing is hidden, changes without notice, or requires a sales call to learn
2	Pricing exists but is confusing — hidden fees, unclear tier structures
3	Pricing is published, but volume discounts and tiers require negotiation
4	Clear pricing tiers on website, volume discounts are transparent
5	Fully transparent pricing, no hidden fees, discounts clearly defined, price-per-lead visible

What to check:

- Can you see pricing on their website without talking to a salesperson?
- Are there setup fees, monthly minimums, or subscription requirements?
- Do they charge differently for different lead ages, verticals, or geographies?
- Is the price per lead consistent, or does it fluctuate unpredictably?

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5. Volume Availability (Weight: Medium)

Can the vendor supply the volume you need, when you need it?

Score	Meaning
1	Frequently out of stock, can't fulfill orders, inconsistent supply
2	Limited inventory in most categories, often can't fulfill specific geographic or vertical requests
3	Adequate volume for common verticals and geographies, may run low on niche requests
4	Strong inventory across major verticals and geographies, consistent fulfillment
5	Deep inventory, can scale to thousands of leads per week, never had a supply issue

What to check:

- Order a test batch and see how quickly it's delivered
- Ask: "What's your current inventory for [vertical] in [state]?"
- Ask: "If I need to scale to [X] leads per week, can you support that?"
- Check if they can provide leads on a recurring schedule (weekly, daily)

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6. Geographic Coverage (Weight: Medium)

Does the vendor cover the areas where you do business?

Score	Meaning
1	Very limited coverage — only a few states or metro areas

2	Coverage in major markets, but gaps in many states
3	Nationwide coverage, but thin inventory in some regions
4	Strong nationwide coverage with filtering by state, county, or zip
5	Complete nationwide coverage with granular geographic filtering (zip code, radius, DMA)

What to check:

- Can you filter leads by your specific state, county, or zip code?
- Is inventory consistent in your region, or do they only have deep stock in certain areas?
- For local businesses: Can they guarantee leads within your service radius?

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7. Vertical Specialization (Weight: Medium)

Does the vendor specialize in your industry?

Score	Meaning
1	Generic data broker with no vertical specialization
2	Claims to have leads in your vertical, but quality suggests otherwise
3	Offers leads in your vertical among many others — decent but not specialized
4	Known specialization in your vertical with dedicated lead types and filtering
5	Deep expertise in your vertical — understands lead types, sub-products, compliance, industry terminology

What to check:

- Does the vendor understand the difference between your lead sub-types? (e.g., term life vs. final expense, purchase vs. refi)
- Do they offer filters specific to your vertical? (e.g., loan amount, coverage type, home value)
- Can they explain where and how the leads were originally generated?

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8. Customer Support (Weight: Low-Medium)

How responsive and helpful is the vendor when you have questions or issues?

Score	Meaning
1	No support, no response to inquiries, impossible to reach a human
2	Slow response (48+ hours), unhelpful or scripted answers
3	Adequate support — responds within 24 hours, can resolve basic issues
4	Good support — responsive, knowledgeable, dedicated account rep
5	Excellent — fast response, proactive communication, strategic guidance, dedicated point of contact

What to check:

- Email them a question before you buy and time the response
- Ask a technical question to see if the support team actually knows the product
- Is there a dedicated account manager, or is it a generic support queue?

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9. Integration Options (Weight: Low-Medium)

Can the vendor deliver leads into your existing workflow?

Score	Meaning
1	CSV download only, no integrations
2	CSV download + basic email delivery
3	Integrates with 1-2 popular CRMs or has an API
4	Integrates with major CRMs (Salesforce, HubSpot, etc.) + API access
5	Full API, CRM integrations, Zapier, real-time delivery options, custom webhooks

What to check:

- Can leads be delivered directly into your CRM?

- Is there an API for automated ordering and delivery?
- What format are the leads delivered in? (CSV, API, direct CRM push)
- Can you set up recurring automated orders?

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10. Reputation & Reviews (Weight: Medium)

What do other buyers say about this vendor?

Score	Meaning
1	No reviews, negative reviews dominate, BBB complaints, scam reports
2	Mixed reviews, some complaints about data quality or returns
3	Generally positive, a few complaints but vendor responds and resolves
4	Strong positive reputation, long track record, active in industry communities
5	Excellent reputation, trusted by top agents and companies, industry awards or recognition, strong referral base

What to check:

- Search "[Vendor name] reviews" and read what comes up
- Check BBB, Trustpilot, Google Reviews, industry-specific forums
- Ask the vendor for references — talk to at least 2 current customers
- Search industry Facebook groups and forums for mentions of the vendor

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Blank Scorecard Template

Copy this table and fill it in for each vendor you evaluate.

Category	Vendor A: _____	Vendor B: _____	Vendor C: _____
1. Data Quality (1-5)	___	___	___
2. Lead Freshness (1-5)	___	___	___
3. Return Policy (1-5)	___	___	___

4. Pricing Transparency (1-5)	___	___	___
5. Volume Availability (1-5)	___	___	___
6. Geographic Coverage (1-5)	___	___	___
7. Vertical Specialization (1-5)	___	___	___
8. Customer Support (1-5)	___	___	___
9. Integration Options (1-5)	___	___	___
10. Reputation & Reviews (1-5)	___	___	___
TOTAL (out of 50)	___	___	___

Scoring guide:

- **40-50:** Excellent vendor — strong buy signal
- **30-39:** Good vendor — worth testing with a larger batch
- **20-29:** Average — proceed with caution, test small
- **Below 20:** Avoid — significant red flags

Weighted Scorecard (Advanced)

If certain factors matter more to your business, use this weighted version. Assign your own multipliers (1x, 1.5x, or 2x) to each category.

Category	Score (1-5)	Weight	Weighted Score
Data Quality	___	x2	___
Lead Freshness	___	x2	___
Return Policy	___	x2	___
Pricing Transparency	___	x1.5	___
Volume Availability	___	x1.5	___
Geographic Coverage	___	x1.5	___

Vertical Specialization	___	x1.5	___
Customer Support	___	x1	___
Integration Options	___	x1	___
Reputation & Reviews	___	x1.5	___
WEIGHTED TOTAL			**___ / 80**

Red Flags to Watch For

Stop and reconsider if you notice any of these:

- **No return policy or "all sales final."** Legitimate vendors stand behind their data.
- **Can't tell you where the leads came from.** If they can't explain the lead source, they may be scraping or buying from questionable sources.
- **Pressure to buy large volumes upfront.** Good vendors are happy to start you with a small test.
- **Pricing that seems too good to be true.** Leads at $0.01-0.05 each are almost always heavily recycled or low-quality data.
- **No website, no reviews, no phone number.** Legitimate lead companies have a real online presence.
- **They guarantee a conversion rate.** No honest vendor can guarantee conversions — too many variables are outside their control.
- **Your leads contain data from DNC-listed numbers.** This puts you at legal risk. Ask if they scrub against the National Do Not Call Registry.
- **Every lead has a Gmail or Yahoo address.** A healthy lead file has a mix of email providers. All-free-email batches may indicate fake form fills.

10 Questions to Ask Every Vendor

Before you buy, ask these questions — and pay attention to how they respond, not just what they say.

1. "Where were these leads originally generated? What website or form did they fill out?"

2. "How many times has each lead been sold before it reaches me?"
3. "What is the exact age of the leads? Can I see the date of inquiry on each record?"
4. "What is your return/credit policy for bad data, and can I get that in writing?"
5. "Can I start with a small test order (25-50 leads) before committing to volume?"
6. "Do you scrub your data against the National Do Not Call Registry?"
7. "What filtering options do I have — geography, lead type, age, price range?"
8. "How are leads delivered, and can they integrate with my CRM?"
9. "Can you provide references from current customers in my vertical?"
10. "What's your minimum order, and are there any recurring fees or contracts?"

Vendor Evaluation Process

Step 1: Research (1 day) Identify 3-4 vendors to evaluate. Check websites, read reviews, ask peers for recommendations.

Step 2: Initial Contact (1-2 days) Reach out to each vendor. Ask the 10 questions above. Note response time and quality.

Step 3: Test Order (1 week) Buy 25-50 leads from your top 2 vendors. Work every lead through your full follow-up cadence.

Step 4: Score (1 day) Fill out the scorecard for each vendor based on your experience with the test batch.

Step 5: Scale (ongoing) Choose your primary vendor and increase volume gradually. Re-evaluate quarterly.

Pro tip: Always maintain a relationship with at least 2 vendors. If your primary vendor has a quality dip or inventory shortage, you need a backup ready to go.

Our Recommendation

We consistently recommend AgedLeadStore.com as a starting point for agents and loan officers buying aged leads. They score well across all 10 categories — particularly on data quality, lead freshness transparency, return policy, and vertical specialization for insurance and mortgage leads.

That said, use this scorecard. Test them against other vendors. The best vendor for you depends on your geography, your vertical, your volume needs, and your budget. The scorecard ensures you make that decision with data, not gut instinct.

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